

Week 6 — Diagnosis by Observation

望診

EAM310 • EAST ASIAN MEDICINE DIAGNOSIS I • VUIM SUMMER 2026

⚠ Quiz 4 — August 21, 2026

Class: Friday August 21, 2026 • 9AM–1PM

Guest Lecturer: Dr. Lixing Lao, Ph.D., L.Ac., MB

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REQUIRED READINGS — DUE BEFORE AUGUST 21

FCM CHAPTER 23 — MACIOCIA

- Diagnosis by Observation — full chapter
- Spirit (Shen), Body, Five-Element body types
- Face colour — all 6 pathological colours
- Face areas & microsystem theory
- Eyes, nose, ears, mouth, lips, teeth, throat

CAM CHAPTER 9 — CHENG XINNONG

- Inspection (望診) as first of Four Methods
- Zang-Xiang theory — organs manifest externally
- Observation of vitality, colour, appearance
- Five Sense Organs & Zang-Fu correspondence
- Integration with the other 3 diagnostic pillars

WEEK 6 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Explain Zang-Xiang theory — why external signs reflect internal organs
- Recognize the 5 Element constitutional body types
- Map face zones per Simple Questions Ch.32 & Spiritual Axis Ch.49
- Interpret nose, ear, mouth, lip, teeth & throat findings
- Identify the 4 signs of Spirit (Shen) & their prognostic value
- Differentiate all 6 pathological face colours & their variants
- Map the 6 eye zones to their corresponding Zang-Fu organs
- Integrate observation findings with the other 3 diagnostic pillars

ASSESSMENT CALENDAR

Date	Event	Material Covered
Aug 7	MIDTERM + Journal 1–25	Weeks 1–4 comprehensive
Aug 14	Week 5 Class	(Prior week material)
Aug 21	⚠ Quiz 4	Diagnosis by Observation — Zang-Xiang, Spirit, Colour, Sense Organs
Aug 28	Quiz 5	Week 7 material
Sep 4	Quiz 6	Week 8 material
Sep 11	FINAL + Journal 26–50	Weeks 6–9 comprehensive

IN-CLASS PRACTICE — WHAT TO EXPECT

OBSERVATION PRACTICE LAB

Week 6 includes partner observation practice with Dr. Lao. Come ready to:

- Assess a partner's Spirit (Shen) — complexion, eye lustre, mental clarity, breathing pattern
- Identify constitutional body type against the 5 Five-Element body types
- Practice mapping observed face colour(s) to face zones (Simple Questions vs Spiritual Axis)
- Record eye, nose, ear, mouth findings in your Pulse/Tongue Journal

Huangdi Neijing (475–221 BCE)	"Viscera inside the body must manifest themselves externally."
Zhu Danxi (1281–1358)	"One should observe and analyse the external manifestations of the patient in order to know what is happening inside the body. For the disease of internal organs must have its manifestations on the body surface."
Zhang Jiebin (1562–1639)	"The zang-fu organs are situated interiorly and manifested exteriorly; therefore, the theory of the zang-fu organs is called Zang Xiang."

藏 Zàng = Interior (the organ itself) • 象 Xiàng = Image / Manifestation (its external sign). This principle is the theoretical foundation for ALL of observation diagnosis — every external sign we read is a window into an internal organ's condition.

THE FOUR DIAGNOSTIC METHODS 四診

Inspection 望診	Observation — uses the eye to assess vitality, colour, appearance, secretions, excretions
Auscultation & Olfaction 聞診	Listening (voice, breath, cough) + smelling (odours) — ONE combined pillar
Inquiry 問診	Structured questioning of the patient's history and complaints
Palpation 切診	Pulse-taking (primary) + abdominal, channel, and point palpation

Dr. Lao's Key Principle: "Any inclination to one aspect while neglecting the other three is one-sided and, therefore, is not suggested." Only by combining all four can a comprehensive and systematic diagnosis be made — observation alone is never sufficient.

OBSERVATION — WHAT WE'RE ACTUALLY LOOKING FOR

Category	What's Assessed
① Vitality (Shen 神)	General manifestation of the body's vital activities — the outward sign of Qi/Blood strength in the Zang-Fu
② Colour (Sè 色)	Colour and lustre of the face — can extend to skin on other body parts
③ Appearance (Xíng 形)	Body shape (strong/weak/heavy/skinny), body movement, and posture
④ Five Sense Organs	Eyes, nose, ears, mouth/lips, tongue — each with direct Zang-Fu correspondence
Overweight + mental depression	Suggests Qi deficiency with Excess Phlegm-Damp
Thin person + dry skin	Indicates insufficiency of Blood
Great weight loss during long illness	Indicates exhaustion of Essential Qi (grave prognosis)

Narrow sense	Vitality/vibrancy reflected in lustre of eyes, sheen of hair, lustre of complexion, and "spirit" of tongue & pulse
Broad sense	The mental–emotional–spiritual state — a strong Shen shows a clear projecting voice, lively expression, alert mind, erect posture, optimistic/mentally strong attitude

HAS SPIRIT (有神) — GOOD PROGNOSIS			
Complexion	Lustre, glowing	Complexion	Dull, no lustre
Eyes	Lustre, vitality, clear	Eyes	Dull, clouded
Mind	Clear, alert	Mind	Unclear, depressed
Breathing	Even, unlaboured	Breathing	Laboured

4 Attributes of Normal Complexion: Lustre (bright, glowing — "has spirit") • A subtle, slightly reddish hue (good Mind state) • "Contained"/veiled colour (as if seen through thin white silk) • Moisture (skin firm = "has Stomach-Qi")

FIVE-ELEMENT CONSTITUTIONAL BODY TYPES		
Element	Physical Traits	Personality Traits
Wood 木	Subtle green complexion tint, small head, long-shaped face, broad shoulders, straight back, tall sinewy body, elegant hands/feet	Developed intelligence; poor physical strength; hard worker; tends to worry, overthink
Fire 火	Red/florid complexion, wide teeth, pointed small head, curly or scanty hair, well-developed shoulder/back/hip muscles, small hands/feet	Quick, energetic, active thinker; short-tempered; walks firmly, shakes body while walking; analyzes deeply
Earth 土	Yellowish complexion, round face, relatively big head, wide jaw, well-developed shoulders/back	(Continue from slides/lecture — steady, nurturing temperament typical of Earth types)
Metal 金	Fair/pale complexion — details per lecture	Poor Metal constitution signs — note from lecture/FCM self-assessment Q4
Water 水	Darker complexion — details per lecture	Note from lecture

Clinical note: A constitutional trait is NOT a diagnostic sign — it reflects the person's baseline, not a current disharmony. Never pathologize a lifelong physical trait.

Colour	Variants & Clinical Meaning
White 白	Dull-pale white = Blood deficiency • Bright-white = Yang deficiency • Bluish-white = Yang deficiency with pronounced Cold
Yellow 黃	Sallow yellow = Stomach/Spleen def or Blood def • Bright orange-yellow = Damp-Heat (Heat > Damp) • Hazy smoky yellow = Damp-Heat (Damp > Heat) • Withered dried-up yellow = Heat in ST/SP • Dull-pale yellow = Cold-Damp in ST/SP • Ash-like yellow = long-standing Dampness • Pale-yellow + red spots = SP def + LV-Blood stasis
Red 紅	Full-Heat: whole face red • Empty-Heat: malar flush (cheekbones only)
Green 青/綠	Liver pattern, interior Cold, pain, or interior Wind • Pale-greenish under eyes = LV-Qi stagnation • Pale-green under eyes = LV-Blood def • Grass-like green = collapse of Liver-Qi (grave)
Blue 藍	Dark-bluish under eyes = Cold in LV channel • White-bluish = Cold or chronic pain • Dull-bluish = severe HT-Yang def + Blood stasis or chronic pain • Bluish (children) = Liver-Wind
Black 黑	Greyish, very dark. Cold, pain, or KD disease (usually KD-Yin def) • Moist black = Cold • Dried-up/burned black = Heat (usu. KD-Yin Empty-Heat)

		Floating vs Deep Colour	
Distinct	Full or Empty condition — Upright (Zheng) Qi still intact	Floating	Exterior, mild, Yang condition
Obscure	More serious condition — Upright Qi failing	Deep	Interior, severe, Yin condition

Zone (Simple Questions Ch. 32)	Organ
Forehead	Heart
Left cheek	Liver
Right cheek	Lung
Nose	Spleen
Chin	Kidney

Spiritual Axis Ch.49 gives a more detailed, separate map. Correspondence reveals 3 possible readings: an actual disharmony (red cheeks = Lung Heat), a constitutional trait (short earlobes = weak Kidneys/short life), or an aetiological factor (bluish forehead in a child = prenatal shock).

Example integration: Greenish colour on tip of nose (Spleen zone) = Liver invading Spleen — the SP disharmony is *secondary* to a LV disharmony. Always cross-reference colour with zone location.

Essence of all five Yin and six Yang organs ascends to the eyes (Spiritual Axis). Clear/lustrous eyes = Mind & Essence in good vitality. Dull/clouded eyes = Mind disturbed, Essence weakened — common in long-standing deep emotional problems.

Eye Zone	Organ	Pathological Sign
Inner/outer corners	Heart	Red corners = Heart-Fire; dull-white = Heat; pale-white = Blood def
Upper eyelid	Spleen (or Tai Yang channels)	—
Lower eyelid	Stomach	Swelling under eyes = Kidney deficiency
Sclera	Lungs	Red sclera = Lung-Heat; yellow sclera = Damp-Heat/jaundice
Iris	Liver	—
Pupil	Kidney	Staring up/forward/sideways = Liver-Wind disturbance

Whole eye red, painful, swollen = exterior invasion of Wind-Heat OR rising Liver-Fire (two possible patterns — differentiate with other signs).

NOSE 鼻 — SPLEEN OPENS INTO THE NOSE	
Tip	Spleen — red tip = Spleen deficiency; greenish tip = Cold in Spleen
Bridge	Liver — red bridge = Liver-Fire

EARS 耳 — KIDNEY OPENS INTO THE EAR	
White ears	Cold pattern
Bluish/dark ears	Pain
Dry, withered, dark lobes	Exhaustion of Kidney-Qi (usu. KD-Yin)
Shiny, moist lobes	Good prognosis
Long, full lobe	Strong Kidneys, good constitution
Small/thin lobe	Poor constitution
Swollen ear	Full pattern (pathogenic factor present)
Thin ear	Deficiency of Qi or Blood

Pale-red, moist, shiny lips	Normal — good Spleen state
Pale lips	Yang or Blood deficiency
Red, dry lips	Heat in Stomach and Spleen
Purple/bluish lips	Blood stasis
Mouth slightly open	Empty pattern
Mouth-breathing	Lung-Qi deficiency (if not from blocked nose)
Swollen + painful gums	Stomach-Heat
Swollen, not painful gums	Empty-Heat of the Stomach
Pale gums	Blood deficiency
Dry teeth	Kidney-Yin deficiency

THROAT — PHARYNX & TONSILS	
Acute pain/redness/swelling	Invasion of exterior Wind-Heat
Chronic pain/redness/swelling	Stomach-Heat
Sore, dry, NOT swollen/red	Lung and/or Kidney-Yin deficiency with Empty-Heat
Red, swollen tonsils + exudate	Wind-Heat invasion, complicated by Toxic Heat in ST/LI
Swollen tonsils, normal colour	Retention of Dampness/Phlegm on background of Qi def

EAM Diagnosis Notes FOLDER_EAM310 • Week 6 Insert August 31, 2026

EAM310 • EAM Diagnosis I • Dr. Lao / Prof. Schrier • Friday 9AM–1PM • Room 303

August 21, 2026

ETIOLOGY	ORGAN SYSTEM	DATE

Response	Percentage
U.S. should take more action to reduce greenhouse gas emissions	85%
U.S. should take less action to reduce greenhouse gas emissions	15%



QUALITY / OVERALL

